

Qianou Christina Ma

✉ qianoum@gmail.com | 🌐 qianouma.com | 💻 mqo00 | 🎓 Qianou Ma

Research Focus

My research lies at the intersection of Human-AI Interaction, Generative AI, and the Learning Sciences. I **design, build, and evaluate LLM applications** to foster AI literacy, optimize human-AI task delegation, and support effective human-AI workflows, especially in **programming** and **computing education**. I conduct **mixed-methods research** to investigate how people collaborate and learn with AI systems, and design systems and frameworks to support training and evaluation of effective human-AI workflows.

Education

Ph.D. in Human-Computer Interaction

CARNEGIE MELLON UNIVERSITY (CMU) Advisors: DR. **KEN KOEDINGER** & DR. **SHERRY TONGSHUANG WU**

Dissertation: Training for the Future: Preparing Humans for Effective Human-AI Programming

Thesis Committee: Dr. Sherry Tongshuang Wu, Dr. Ken Koedinger, Dr. Brad Myers, Dr. Elena Glassman

Sept. 2022 - now

Pittsburgh, PA

M.S. in Human-Computer Interaction

CARNEGIE MELLON UNIVERSITY (CMU)

Relevant Coursework: Deep Learning; Advanced NLP; LLM Systems; AI Tools for SDE; Learning Media Design; Persuasive Design

Dec. 2024

Pittsburgh, PA

B.S. in Computer Science & B.S. in Cognitive Science

CARNEGIE MELLON UNIVERSITY (CMU) MINOR IN DESIGN FOR LEARNING. QPA: 3.91/4.0

May 2022

Pittsburgh, PA

Research & Work Experience

Applied Science Intern, Microsoft

MENTORS: DR. SHAMSI IQBAL, DR. SIDDARTH SURI & DR. PRANAV KHAPE

- Leading an *empirical study* (paper in submission [P1]) on how expertise shapes agentic work and translating research to AI upskilling insights.
- Analyzing *human profiles* and *interaction behaviors and trajectories* to identify factors that predict a better future of work with LLM agents.

Redmond, WA

2026 Summer

PhD Researcher, Carnegie Mellon University

ADVISORS: DR. KEN KOEDINGER & DR. SHERRY TONGSHUANG WU

- Designed and built new measures and LLM-based learning tools to develop AI literacy resilient to model updates (see summary at [W1]). E.g., a teachable agent for CS1 debugging (HypoCompass [P12]) and a tutor to help end-users program in prompts (ROPE [P10]).
- Led *mixed-methods research* (literature reviews [W7, P11], controlled experiments [P10], classroom study [P8], and pre-post user studies [P12, P6], and conducted statistical modeling, log analysis, and qualitative coding to evaluate human-AI collaboration and learning effectiveness.
- Collaborated with *interdisciplinary teams* to co-author 10+ peer-reviewed papers (e.g., NLP [P5, W6], CSEd [P14, W5], SWE [P9], HCI [P8]), including a first-authored Best Paper [P12] and Honorable Mention [P13] and multiple invited presentations (IJCAI, CSCL).

Pittsburgh, PA

2022 - present

Selected Publications

MANUSCRIPTS AND PRE-PRINTS

- [P1] **Qianou Ma**, Pranav Khape, Rock Pang, Ken Koedinger, Tongshuang Wu, Siddarth Suri, and Shamsi Iqbal. Impact of expertise and trust on ai-assisted work. In *Submission*, 2027.
- [P2] Yeon Su Park, Nadia Arvi, Hae Ri Lee, Sehoon Lim, **Qianou Ma**, and Juho Kim. **The Work Behind Delegation: A Framework for Supervising AI Coding Agents**. In *Submission*, 2027.
- [P3] Zora Zhiruo Wang, Apurva Gandhi, Rulin Shao, Aspen Chen, Jonas Mueller, Zhiqi Liang, Jett Chen, Michael Ryan, **Qianou Ma**, Luxi He, et al. **Efficient Test-Time Adaptation through Human-AI Interaction**. In *NeurIPS TTCL Workshop (accepted)*, 2026.
- [P4] Xuhui Zhou*, Weiwei Sun*, Weihua Du, Jiarui Liu, Haojia Sun, **Qianou Ma**, Tongshuang Wu, Yiming Yang, and Maarten Sap. **OdysSim: Building Foundation Models for Human Behavior Simulation**. In *NeurIPS (accepted)*, 2026. *Equal contribution.

- [P5] Xuhui Zhou*, Weiwei Sun*, **Qianou Ma**, Yiqing Xie, Jiarui Liu, Weihua Du, Sean Welleck, Yiming Yang, Graham Neubig, Tongshuang Wu, et al. [Mind the Sim2Real Gap in User Simulation for Agentic Tasks](#). In *COLM (accepted)*, 2026. *Equal contribution.

PEER-REVIEWED CONFERENCE AND JOURNAL PUBLICATIONS

- [P6] **Qianou Ma**, Megan Chai, Yike Tan, Jihun Choi, Jini Kim, Erik Harpstead, Geoff Kauffman, and Tongshuang Wu. [“GenAI Defaults to Bias!” Gamify AI literacy through Reflections on Prompts](#). In *International Conference on Artificial Intelligence in Education (AIED)*, 2026. Code: </>.
- [P7] **Qianou Ma***, Keyu He*, Valerie Chen, Wayne Chi, and Tongshuang Wu. [RECAP: An End-to-End Platform for Capturing, Replaying, and Analyzing AI-Assisted Programming Interactions](#). In *Proceedings of the 64th Annual Meeting of the Association for Computational Linguistics (Volume 3: System Demonstrations)*, 2026. Code: </>. *Equal contribution.
- [P8] **Qianou Ma**, Ken Koedinger, and Tongshuang Wu. [Not Everyone Wins with LLMs: Behavioral Patterns and Pedagogical Implications for AI Literacy in Programmatic Data Science](#). In *Proceedings of the 2026 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems*, 2026. Code: </>.
- [P9] Chenyang Yang, Yike Shi, **Qianou Ma**, Michael Xieyang Liu, Christian Kästner, and Tongshuang Wu. [What Prompts Don’t Say: Understanding and Managing Underspecification in LLM Prompts](#). In *Findings of the Association for Computational Linguistics: ACL*, 2026.
- [P10] **Qianou Ma**, Weirui Peng, Chenyang Yang, Hua Shen, Kenneth Koedinger, and Tongshuang Wu. [What Should We Engineer in Prompts? Training Humans in Requirement-Driven LLM Use](#). In *Transactions on Computer-Human Interaction (TOCHI)*, 2025. Presented at CHI’26. Media coverage: [SCS News](#); [New York Times](#). Code: </>.
- [P11] **Qianou Ma***, Dora Zhao*, Xinran Zhao, Chenglei Si, Chenyang Yang, Ryan Louie, Ehud Reiter, Diyi Yang, and Tongshuang Wu. [SPHERE: An Evaluation Card for Human-AI System Evaluation](#). In *ACL Findings*, 2025. Media coverage: [MIT AHA Workshop](#). Code: </>. *Equal contribution.
- [P12] **Qianou Ma**, Hua Shen, Kenneth Koedinger, and Tongshuang Wu. [How to Teach Programming in the AI Era? Using LLMs as a Teachable Agent for Debugging](#). In *International Conference on Artificial Intelligence in Education (AIED)*, 2024. 🏆 **Best Paper** 🏆 **Best Interactive Event**. Invited presentations at IJCAI’25 and CSCL’25. Media coverage: [The Link](#), [New York Times](#). Code: </>.
- [P13] Atharva Naik, Jessica Ruhan Yin, Anusha Kamath, **Qianou Ma**, Sherry Tongshuang Wu, Charles Murray, Christopher Bogart, Majd Sakr, and Carolyn P. Rose. [Generating Situated Reflection Triggers About Alternative Solution Paths: A Case Study in Generative AI for Computer-Supported Collaborative Learning](#). In *International Conference on Artificial Intelligence in Education*. Springer, 2024. 🏆 **Best Paper Nominee**.
- [P14] Atharva Naik, Jessica Ruhan Yin, Anusha Kamath, **Qianou Ma**, Sherry Tongshuang Wu, R. Charles Murray, Christopher Bogart, Majd Sakr, and Carolyn P. Rose. [Providing tailored reflection instructions in collaborative learning using large language models](#). *British Journal of Educational Technology*, 20, 2024.

PEER-REVIEWED WORKSHOP, POSTERS & WORK-IN-PROGRESS

- [W1] **Qianou Ma**. [Training for the Future: Preparing Humans for Effective Human-AI Programming](#). In *CHI EA’26: Extended Abstracts of the CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (Doctoral Consortium)*, 2026.
- [W2] **Qianou Ma**, Sherry Tongshuang Wu, and Kenneth R. Koedinger. [What Calculus Should We Teach in the Age of AI? Identifying and Improving Higher-Order Thinking in College Math](#). In *Artificial Intelligence in Education Doctoral Consortium*. 2026.
- [W3] Ruiwei Xiao, Shan Zhang, Xinying Hou, Ying-Jui Tseng, **Qianou Ma**, Yash Tadimalla, Qing Xiao, Jionghao Lin, Bo Jiang, John Stamper, and Kenneth R. Koedinger. [AI Literacy For All: 2nd International Workshop on AI Literacy Education For All](#). In *Artificial Intelligence in Education FoL Workshops*. 2026.
- [W4] **Qianou Ma**, Anika Jain*, Jini Kim*, Megan Chai*, and Geoff Kauffman. [ImaginAltion: Promoting Generative AI Literacy Through Game-Based Learning](#). In *CHI EA’25: Extended Abstracts of the CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems*, 2025. *Equal contribution.
- [W5] Aysa Xuemo Fan, Rully Agus Hendrawan, Yang Shi, and **Qianou Ma**. [Enhancing Code Tracing Question Generation with Refined Prompts in Large Language Models](#). *SIGCSE TS (55th ACM Technical Symposium on Computer Science Education)*, 2024.
- [W6] **Qianou Ma***, Yann Hicke*, Anmol Agarwal*, and Paul Denny. [AI-TA: Towards an Intelligent Question-Answer Teaching Assistant using Open-Source LLMs](#). In *Proceedings of the Workshop on GenAI for Education @NeurIPS*, 2023. *Equal contribution.
- [W7] **Qianou Ma**, Tongshuang Wu, and Kenneth Koedinger. [Is AI the better programming partner? Human-Human Pair Programming vs. Human-AI pAIr Programming](#). In *Proceedings of the Workshop on LLMs@AIED*, 2023. Presented at ICER’23.

Awards & Fellowships

HONORS & AWARDS

2026	Fellow on AI & Society , Block Center for Technology and Society	Pittsburgh, PA
2024	Best Paper , top-1 best paper [P12] awarded at AIED 2024	Recife, Brazil
2024	Best Interactive Event , top-1 best interactive event [P12] at AIED 2024	Recife, Brazil
2024	Best Paper Nominee , top-6 best paper nominee [P13] at AIED 2024	Recife, Brazil
2023	Generative AI Innovation Incubator (GAI3) Hackathon , 1st place team awarded with \$20,000	Pittsburgh, PA
2021	Phi Beta Kappa , 1 of 16 seniors selected in Fall 2021	Pittsburgh, PA

FELLOWSHIPS & FUNDINGS

2026	What Calculus Should We Teach in the Age of AI? Identifying and Improving Higher-Order Thinking in Math , Learnvia Seed Grant (Role: Co-PI; led proposal writing)	\$150,000
2025	RealEduArena: Evaluating LLMs' Pedagogical Implementations in Real AI Tutoring , Google Gift Fund on Evaluations and Benchmarks (Role: lead PhD researcher)	\$75,000
2025	ImaginAltion: Promoting Generative AI Literacy Through Game-Based Learning , CMU GSA/Provost Conference Fund	\$1500
2024	Explicitly Train Humans towards Human-AI Collaboration , Google Academic Research Award (Role: lead PhD researcher; contributed to proposal writing)	\$100,000
2021	Support Designer-Teacher Collaboration in Educational Game Design Using Learning Science Principles , CMU Dietrich College Senior Honors Fellowship	\$6500
2020	The contribution of local and global language statistics to developing structured semantic networks , CMU Summer Undergraduate Research Fellowship	\$3500
2020	Improving Web Visualization to Support Teachers & Parents: a Case Study of the Carnegie Museum of Art , CMU Small Undergraduate Research Grant	\$500
2019	Linguistic patterns differentially predict children's semantic structure relatedness , Ireland Undergraduate Research Fund	\$1750

Presentations & Talks

2026 Summer	Invited Talk , The Impact of Expertise on AI-assisted Work	Microsoft
2026 Spring	Invited Talk , What to Teach and How to Teach Programming in the AI Era Penn; Cornell; Columbia; UMich; UChicago; UIUC; UCI; UCSD; UCB; Stanford; UW	Various Schools
2025 Fall	Invited Talk , Training Future Proof Developers	HKU; HKUST; ECNU
2025 Fall	Invited Keynote , AI x Future of Work Series: Workforce Preparation on AI Literacy	Plug & Play Tech Center
2025 Fall	Invited Talk , Training Requirement-Driven LLM Use for Prompt Programming	Mila HCAI seminar
2025	Invited Talk , Training the Use of LLMs on Programmatic Data Science for Non-Experts	Bloomberg; Pitt
2025 Summer	Invited Talk , IJCAI 2025 Sister Conferences' Best Paper Presentation	Montreal, Canada
2025 Summer	Invited Talk , CSCL/ISLS 2025 IAALDE-Network Best Paper Presentation	Helsinki, Finland
2024 Fall	Invited Talk , Scaling Student Support: Online Question-Answering with LLM Tutors	Google DeepMind
2024 Fall	Invited Talk , Training for the Future: Preparing Students for Human-LLM Partnerships	UMich; CMU; Pitt

Teaching & Mentoring Experience

2023-present	Mentor , Independent Studies or Projects on LLM-assisted Learning Advised students from LS, HCI, CS, and NLP on various projects [P10, P13, P12, W4], now UMich PhD, CMU PhD, etc.	8 Undergrad/grad; 1 HS
2024 Fall	Mentor , CMU Paths to AI Research Program for traditionally underrepresented	2 Undergraduates
2022, 2024	Mentor , CMU SCS Graduate Application Support Program for underrepresented	3 Master's students
2023, 2024	Mentor , CMU LearnLab Summer School Computing Education Research (e.g., [W5])	7 Ph.D. and 1 Master's

2026 Fall	Guest Lecturer , CMU 05-315/615 Persuasive Design	60+ Undergrad/grad
2026 Spring	Guest Lecturer , CMU 05-840 Tools for Online Learning	25+ Undergrad/grad
2026 Spring	Guest Lecturer , CMU 05-499/899 AI Augmented Designer	60+ Undergrad/grad
2025 Fall	Guest Lecturer , University of Michigan EECS-498 AI in Education	15+ Undergrad/grad
2025 Summer	Guest Lecturer , Northeastern INFO-7375 Prompt Engineering for Generative AI	40+ Undergrad/grad
2025 Spring	Guest Lecturer , CMU 05-898 HCI & Data Science for Product Managers	40+ Undergrad/grad
2024 Summer	Guest Lecturer , CMU 82-183 AI for Humanities: The Multi-dimensions of World	20+ Undergraduate
2024 Fall	Teaching Assistant , CMU 05-430/630 Programming Usable Interfaces	70+ Undergrad/grad
2023 Fall	Teaching Assistant , CMU 05-391/891 Design Human-Centered Software	60+ Undergrad/grad
2021 Fall	Teaching Assistant , CMU 15-110 Principles of Computing	300+ Undergraduates
2021 Summer	Teaching Assistant , CMU CS Scholar Pre-College Program <i>for underrepresented</i>	30+ Grades 9-12
2021 Spring	Teaching Assistant , CMU 15-150 Functional Programming (Reflection Blog)	300+ Undergraduates

Service & Leadership Experience

2024 - present	Program Committee , Various conferences NeurIPS GAIED (2023), EDM (2024-26), SIGCSE (2025), ICLR BiAlign (2025), AIED (2026), ALIT4ALL (2026), NeurIPS BiAlign (2026)	
2022 - present	Reviewer , Various conferences and journals ACM CHI (2023-26), UIST (2024-26), Computers & Education (2024) 🏆 <i>Special Recognitions for Outstanding Reviews</i> (ACM CHI)	
2019 - present	Member , CMU University Disciplinary Committee & Academic Review Board	Pittsburgh, PA
2026 - 2027	Publicity Chair , Human-AI Interaction Conference (HAIC)	Washington, DC
2026 Summer	Student Volunteer , CHI (2026)	Barcelona, Spain
2026 Summer	Organizer , AIED Workshop: 2nd Workshop on AI Literacy Education for All [W3]	Seoul, South Korea
2026 Spring	Panelist , CHI Workshop: Human-Human Collaboration to Human-Agent Collaboration	Barcelona, Spain
2025 Fall	Invited Expert , MIT Media Lab Benchmarks for Human Flourishing with AI Workshop	Boston, MA
2025 Spring	Co-leader , NSF I-Corps Team for LLM-powered Teaching Assistant Project	Pittsburgh, PA
2025 Spring	Member , HCII NSF Research Experiences for Undergrad (REU) Admissions Committee	Pittsburgh, PA
2025 Spring	Member , CMU HCII Ph.D. Admissions Committee	Pittsburgh, PA
2025 Spring	Panelist , K-12 AI Teacher Professional Development at Eberly Center	Pittsburgh, PA
2024 Fall	Panelist , CMU School of Computer Science Freshman Immigration Course	Pittsburgh, PA
2023 Spring	Director , CMU School of Computer Science Graduate Student Musical Organize and direct a musical revue with 30+ performers and 200+ audience	Pittsburgh, PA
2022 Fall	Co-leader , CMU Women@SCS TechNights (data bias session) Help organize a session on training data and a data bias card game for 20+ middle-school Black girls	Pittsburgh, PA
2021 Fall	Member , CMU Teaching Innovation Award Selection Committee	Pittsburgh, PA
2018 - 2022	President (21-22), VP of Communications (20), Project Advisor (18-19), Project Ignite Recruit college students to provide free interdisciplinary project-based learning opportunities to local high-school students, increase diversity in high-school student applications, and facilitate about 100 workshop sessions per year	Pittsburgh, PA
2018 - present	Docent , Carnegie Museum of Art (CMOA), leading public tours and school tours	Pittsburgh, PA